

I need to talk for about five or ten minutes about, you know, what made me—what I believe contributed to my becoming an atheist. I grew up in a Christian family, and what I experienced in the Quran changed my perception.

Let me start out by mentioning that my mother certainly played no role in my becoming an atheist. My mother had tremendous dignity and class. The neighbors loved her. She was a registered nurse and put in many extra hours at the hospital. When she died, her funeral was packed, and person after person who came up to me had a story to tell about my mother and her goodness. She was a deeply religious woman, a great mother, a great teacher.

My father, on the other hand, was a difficult man. For some strange reason, he had tremendous rage inside him. He had terrible violence inside him, and his drinking only made him more volatile. This would happen night after night. My four brothers and I—I was the fourth in line—lived a frightening and precarious childhood.

But I'd have to say the worst of it was watching my father regularly taunt, threaten, and abuse my mother. It would happen day in, day out, night in, night out. You see, it's really not so bad when you're the target of your father's violence. You might think it's bad when a child is the target of their father's violence. At the moment of attack, you're really not thinking about anything except your own survival. When he's threatening you—"I'm going to hurt you, bad boy"—you're not thinking about anything except escape.

But a far worse fear is the terror that overcomes you when you watch your father go after your mother. She's the only source of warmth, kindness, love, and protection that you know from a little boy's standpoint, and you lost everything.

Far worse than the fear is the guilt. It comes over you from several directions. First, there's the guilt from your growing antipathy towards your father. We're taught to love and respect our parents, and we are born with a natural bonding attachment to them. But when you watch something like this happen night after night, this rage is growing inside you. You're being pulled in opposite directions.

The worst guilt of all—and it is by far the very worst—is knowing that you did nothing to stop your father from hurting your mother. You come to realize, with ever greater clarity, your own weakness, impotence, incompetence, worthlessness, and cowardice. The hate grows and festers inside you, not only for the man you call father, but for yourself as well.

It is a terrible thing to make a young boy choose between his mother and himself. When I was little, I used to daydream about life without my father. I just wanted the violence to go away. I wanted not to be

afraid anymore. I felt like I was trapped in a bad dream with no way out.

So I prayed to God again and again to remove my father from our lives, but he was always there. Very soon, I began to wonder if God really was. I could not understand why God would subject my mom to such lifelong punishment. I could not imagine what great sin she must have committed, or that we, her children, must have committed to deserve my father. I was too young to see the wisdom in allowing my mom to suffer the violence and abuse of my father. I was too young to understand why God would let innocent children tremble night after night in their beds. I was too young to see how the mercy of God could even extend to my father with all his terrible failings. All I could see was chaos, violence, and fear.

It became easy for me to question the existence of God. I began to do that at a very early age. Why didn't He just make us angels and put us into heaven?

If He could make us angels—which I always thought He could—is this the best world He could create?

I just couldn't figure it out. All the explanations I received from priests, doctors, and others just didn't make sense to me.

I became an atheist when I was 16, even though I was going to Catholic school at the time. I declared myself an atheist in one class after a confrontation with a priest.

We were talking about God and the purpose of life. I expressed my views, and he said, “Well then, you don't believe in God?” I said, “Well, I guess I don't.”

When I was 28, to make a long story short, some friends gave me a copy of the Quran. One night, I was sitting in Diamond Heights, ran out of stuff to read, and took this gift.

I began to read it. I came to the first verse, read the first page, and in the second Surah, about 37 verses in, I came upon the story of mankind. I have to admit, I read through it very quickly. It was about nine or ten verses long—the story of the first man and woman. I recognized some details similar to what I had learned as a child, but I noticed something wrong.

It was apparent to me that whoever authored this Quran—of course, I wasn't a Muslim at the time, so I didn't know who that was—clearly did not understand the real meaning of the story.

I read through it once, then again, a third and fourth time, to understand the author's point.

Finally, I realized something strange was going on. I needed to go through this story line by line, verse by verse, because it was obvious the author was trying to bring out another point.

I came to the 30th verse of the second Surah, Al-Baqara, and it began like this:

“Behold, your Lord said to the angels, ‘I am going to place a vicant on Earth.’”

The Arabic word is *Khalifa*. It means a representative or an emissary of mine. The angels said, “*Will you place therein one who will spread corruption and shed blood while we celebrate your praises and glorify your holiness?*” Allah said, “*Truly, I know what you do not know.*”

That verse hooked me. It caught my attention. It made me read the story again and again. “I’m going to place a representative of mine on Earth, a vicant of mine, an emissary, one who acts on my behalf.” I thought, “That’s not the way it goes. You’re not supposed to place man on Earth in some elective office; you place man as punishment for his sin.”

But then the angels questioned it again. They said, “Will you place therein one who will spread corruption and shed blood while we celebrate your praises and glorify you?”

I looked at that and thought, “Exactly—that would be my question. Why create this being when he is capable of tremendous wrongdoing, when he could spread corruption and shed blood? Why create this violent and pernicious creature when you could create angels?”

It’s one of the most fundamental questions in the history of religion. The question is asked in heaven. It’s almost like the angels are saying, “Why don’t you just make him angels and be up here in heaven with us?”

God’s answer: “Truly, I know what you do not know.” In modern terms, “I know exactly what I’m doing.” This theme appears repeatedly in the Quran. It taught me that *Allah’s ways and wisdom are beyond human understanding.*

Then, Allah taught Adam the names of all things. He placed them before the angels and said, “Tell me their names if you are right.” This shows that mankind is a learning creature. Allah emphasizes man’s intellect—the ability to learn, to name, to reason.

Human beings can do evil and wrong, but they can also choose to do tremendous good, show compassion, or live by truth. Up until that point, I had only seen the evil potentials of human beings. *Reading this verse revealed the dual nature of man.*

Then comes Satan—El. He refused to bow to Adam out of arrogance. This introduces evil into human experience. The Quran presents mankind as both intellectual and moral beings.

God's instructions to Adam and his spouse about the garden are warnings, not punishments. Even when they slip, it's a minor error—a "slip."

The greatest sin in human history, according to the Quran, is momentary loss of focus. Allah doesn't punish with rage or violence; He prepares mankind to make independent choices.

Adam is given the **power to choose**. This is the true gift from Allah—intellect, learning, and moral agency. Allah is merciful, guiding mankind, giving him freedom to act, and showing that His wisdom encompasses all outcomes.

In this story, we see that Allah's guidance is patient and compassionate. For the first time, I understood that human suffering, misfortune, and evil are not necessarily divine punishment, but part of a process preparing mankind to learn, grow, and exercise moral judgment.

Picture this: a young couple, fearful and ashamed, feeling remorse. Allah reaches out to them and tells them, **"You have nothing to fear, nor shall you grieve. I know this is tough for you, but you've been prepared for it. This is a necessary stage in your development and growth. Hang in there. Follow my guidance. Be true to me, and I'll be true to you. I'll guide you, help you, and provide what you need. Follow my guidance, and you have nothing to fear nor shall you grieve."**